

Teaching Statement

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I view teaching as an essential part of my academic career, both as a means of helping students develop economic reasoning and as an opportunity to deepen my own understanding through interaction with them. At the University of Pittsburgh, I have independently designed and taught *Introduction to Microeconomics* twice, and have served as a teaching assistant for both the undergraduate *Introduction to Microeconomics* and the PhD-level *Introduction to Mathematical Methods*, where I led recitation sessions, and for *Health Economics* and *Development Economics*, where I held office hours. These experiences have shaped and sharpened my teaching philosophy and approach.

Economics offers a powerful lens to study a broad range of social questions. My teaching philosophy centers on equipping students with a structured economic framework for analyzing real-world problems scientifically. I view this ability to think independently and critically as especially valuable in today's world, where students regularly encounter overwhelming and competing claims about economic and social issues from the media. To put this philosophy into practice, I focus on three principal goals: (1) providing clear explanations in class, (2) giving students opportunities for hands-on application, and (3) fostering an inclusive environment where every student feels comfortable asking questions and sharing their perspectives.

Fostering Clear Understanding. To build clarity, I structure lectures into digestible segments. Each class begins with a brief review of previous material, followed by a preview of the current topic to help students connect concepts to the bigger picture. I then move into detailed discussion of economic concepts and methods, using real-world examples to make abstract ideas concrete. I also invite students to share their own examples, which helps deepen students' understanding. After introducing each concept, I incorporate a short in-class activity to reinforce comprehension and address questions promptly. Having been a student myself, I understand that engagement and interest are powerful catalysts for learning. I use different formats of in-class activities to spark students' interest. For example, I have students play a simple game to illustrate market failure, which later increases engagement and discussion in class. I conclude each lecture with a problem-solving session in which students work in small groups and present their reasoning to the class. Students have responded positively to this approach, as reflected in comments such as: "*Yu Qiu's explanations are incredibly clear and simple, and allow students to grasp the concepts discussed in lectures quite easily. The problems provided during classes also allow for frequent implementation of acquired skills and knowledge, which is quite helpful. It is clear she has her students' best interests at heart*" and "*I liked that she was very thorough when explaining the examples and answered every question in detail. She was very enthusiastic which made me want to pay more attention and understand better.*"

Applying Knowledge Beyond the Classroom. I design after-class assignments to encourage application of the in-class knowledge and independent thinking on real-world problems. In addition to problem sets that help enhance the understanding of the material, I

also design analysis exercises that require students to connect the framework learned in class to real-world phenomena. For example, in my *Introduction to Microeconomics* class, I asked students to read an article describing the post-COVID “donut effect” in the housing market, which is the phenomenon of rising suburban housing prices alongside declining city-center prices, and analyze the phenomenon using the supply and demand framework learned in the class. Several students told me that they found these exercises both eye-opening and useful.

Creating an Inclusive Environment. I aim to make my classroom a space where all students feel welcome and comfortable participating. On the first day of the class, I encourage students to ask questions by emphasizing that every question is valuable and benefits the whole class. In each class, I pause regularly to invite questions, move around the classroom and make eye contact when teaching in person, and use chat prompts or anonymous polls when teaching on Zoom to encourage engagement from students who may be less comfortable speaking out. Outside of class, I make myself available through emails and office hours, ensuring that students can seek help and share thoughts in a supportive setting.

Ultimately, my aim is for students to leave my course not only with a solid understanding of economics as a subject but also with the confidence and skills to apply it, whether in understanding social and economic issues or making decisions in their own lives. By combining clear explanations, practical application, and an inclusive classroom culture, I hope to make economics both meaningful and empowering for all my students.

Teaching Interests. I look forward to contributing to both teaching and mentoring students in the department. I am prepared to teach introductory and intermediate microeconomics, as well as courses in labor economics, development economics, political economy, and economic history. I would also be excited to teach policy-oriented courses that apply economic reasoning and empirical methods to questions of public policy, and to develop courses that align with the school’s curricular needs.